

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 69

By Martin B

A RESOLUTION relative to a plan to make Tennessee healthy.

WHEREAS, chronic diseases, including diabetes, obesity, and heart disease, account for over 70 percent of healthcare costs and are the leading cause of death and disability in the United States, impacting millions of families and straining public resources; and

WHEREAS, the chronic disease epidemic especially harms our young people, with 50 percent of young adults being obese, 77 percent of young adults being ineligible for military service, and 40 percent of high school students having a mental health disorder; and

WHEREAS, 60 percent of Americans have a chronic disease; and

WHEREAS, 90 percent of deaths are tied to preventable chronic diseases; and

WHEREAS, 90 percent of chronic diseases are reversible; and

WHEREAS, the root causes of chronic disease are linked to preventable factors such as poor nutrition, sedentary lifestyles, and lack of access to health education; and

WHEREAS, public policies that incentivize better health provide meaningful results that empower people and communities; and

WHEREAS, the State of Tennessee and the United States require a paradigm shift in healthcare policy that emphasizes the role of nutrition, exercise, and lifestyle medicine in preventing and reversing chronic disease; and

WHEREAS, the State of Tennessee has a responsibility to its citizens to ensure government policy serves to improve public health outcomes, reduce healthcare costs, and provide citizens the tools and resources to lead healthy, productive lives; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE

CONCURRING, that the State support and adopt the following principles and priorities for a healthier citizenry:

1. Reform the Food Economy.

a. The Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) should exclude ultra-processed, high-sugar, and high-fat junk foods while incentivizing fresh, nutrient-dense options.

b. State partnerships with local farmers, grocers, and schools should seek to increase access to healthy, affordable food in underserved areas.

c. Crop subsidies should incentivize healthy, whole foods instead of ultra-processed foods.

2. Support Lifestyle Medicine and Education.

a. Integration of health and wellness curricula into K-12 schools, focusing on nutrition, exercise, and the long-term benefits of healthy living, would make our children healthier.

b. Greater public access to lifestyle medicine practitioners through state healthcare programs and partnerships with medical schools would improve health outcomes.

c. Utilization of health savings accounts and flexible spending accounts to cover more holistic and preventative care, such as exercise costs and nutritional supplements, would create opportunities for better health.

3. Encourage Good Governance.

a. Conflicts of interest in the FDA, USDA, and other regulatory agencies lead to flawed nutrition standards and must be eliminated.

b. Toxins banned in other developed countries are poisoning our food, water, and consumer goods and should be banned here as well.

- c. The FDA's slow and costly approval process stifles healthcare innovation.
- 4. Lead by Example in State Institutions.
 - a. Food served in state facilities, including schools and government offices, should meet high nutritional standards.
 - b. Wellness programs and resources for state employees reduce healthcare costs and improve productivity.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that a certified copy of this resolution be transmitted to the Governor of Tennessee, the Commissioner of Health, and the members of Tennessee's congressional delegation, urging their active support and advocacies for policies that align with these principles and requesting their participation in an annual "Make Tennessee Healthy" summit to advance these goals for the health of all Tennesseans.